

CHAPTER 8

Bholi

NCERT Exercise Solutions

Bholi · Read and Find Out (1) 2 Q
Bholi · Read and Find Out (2) 2 Q
Bholi · Read and Find Out (3) 2 Q
Bholi · Think about It 5 Q
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✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

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⭐ Bholi · Read and Find Out (1)

1 **Why is Bholi's father worried about her?**

✔ ANSWER

Ramlal is worried because Bholi has **neither good looks nor intelligence**. Her face is disfigured by pock-marks, she stammers and is a backward child, so he fears no one will marry her, unlike her good-looking, healthy sisters.

2 **For what unusual reasons is Bholi sent to school?**

✔ ANSWER

The Tehsildar told Ramlal to set an example by sending his daughters to school. His wife feared that educated girls would not get married. Since there was **little chance of Bholi getting married anyway**, with her ugly face and lack of sense, they sent her: "Let the teachers at school worry about her."

⭐ Bholi · Read and Find Out (2)

1 **Does Bholi enjoy her first day at school?**

✔ ANSWER

Yes. At first she is frightened and cries when the girls laugh at her stammer. But she is glad to see so many girls of her age, likes the coloured pictures, and the teacher's kindness fills her heart with **"a new hope and a new life"**.

2 **Does she find her teacher different from the people at home?**

✔ ANSWER

Yes. At home she was neglected and called a fool. The teacher speaks in a **soft and soothing** voice, encourages her, pats her affectionately and promises that she will speak like everyone else. No one had ever spoken to her like that.

⭐ Bholi · Read and Find Out (3)

1 **Why do Bholi's parents accept Bishamber's marriage proposal?**

✔ ANSWER

Bishamber is a **well-to-do** grocer with a big shop, his own house and money in the bank, and he asks for **no dowry**. He is from another village and does not know about Bholi's pock-marks and 'lack of sense'. Her parents fear that otherwise she may remain unmarried all her life.

2 **Why does the marriage not take place?**

✔ ANSWER

On seeing Bholi's pock-marks, Bishamber demands **five thousand rupees** as dowry. Ramlal pays it in tears. Bholi is disgusted by his greed and cowardice, flings the garland into the fire and refuses to marry such a **"mean, greedy and contemptible coward"**.

🤔 Bholi · Think about It

1 **Bholi had many apprehensions about going to school. What made her feel that she was going to a better place than her home?**

✔ ANSWER

Bholi was frightened, remembering how their cow Lakshmi had been turned out and sold. But that day she was given a **clean dress** (Champa's old one), she was **bathed** and **oil was rubbed into her dry, matted hair**. She had never been cared for like this, so she began to believe she was being taken to a place better than her home.

2 **How did Bholi's teacher play an important role in changing the course of her life?**

✔ ANSWER

- **Kindness:** she called Bholi in a soft, soothing voice, something Bholi had never known.
- **Encouragement:** she patiently helped her say her name, praised her ("Well done") and told her to put the fear out of her heart.
- **Hope:** she gave her a picture book and promised that with learning she would speak without a stammer and people would respect her.
- **Result:** education gave Bholi confidence and self-respect. She spoke clearly at her wedding, rejected a greedy man and decided to teach in the same school.

So the teacher changed a neglected, stammering 'simpleton' into a bold, educated young woman.

3 **Why did Bholi at first agree to an unequal match? Why did she later reject the marriage? What does this tell us about her?**

✔ ANSWER

- **Agreed:** for the sake of her family's **izzat** (honour), she was willing to marry the lame old man, as her parents wished.
- **Rejected:** when Bishamber demanded five thousand rupees as dowry after seeing her face and humiliated her father, she saw he was a **"mean, greedy and contemptible coward"**.

- **What it shows:** she is sensible, self-respecting and brave. Education had made her confident; she could stand up against greed and injustice and was no longer a “dumb-driven cow”.

4 **Bholi’s real name is Sulekha. We are told this right at the beginning. But only in the last but one paragraph of the story is Bholi called Sulekha again. Why do you think she is called Sulekha at that point in the story?**

✔ ANSWER

‘Bholi’ means a simpleton. By the end she is no longer one: she speaks clearly and calmly, rejects a greedy groom and plans to serve her parents and teach in the school. She has become a **confident, educated and mature** woman, so the writer calls her by her real name, **Sulekha**, to show this change in her identity.

5 **Bholi's story must have moved you. Do you think girl children are not treated at par with boys? You are aware that the government has introduced a scheme to save the girl child as the sex ratio is declining. The scheme is called Beti Bachao Beti Padhao, Save the Girl Child. Read about the scheme and design a poster in groups of four and display on the school notice board.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Yes, in many homes girls are still not treated at par with boys. In the story, Ramlal's sons study in city schools and colleges, while the girls only wait to be married.

Model poster (sample):

BETI BACHAO, BETI PADHAO

Save the Girl Child · Educate the Girl Child

- A daughter is a blessing, not a burden.
- Stop female foeticide – every girl has the right to be born.
- Send every girl to school – an educated girl builds an educated family.
- Say NO to dowry and child marriage.

Picture idea: a smiling girl in uniform holding books.

Issued by: Eco/Social Club, (school name) · Ministry of Women & Child Development, Government of India

⭐ Bholi · Talk about It

1 **Bholi's teacher helped her overcome social barriers by encouraging and motivating her. How do you think you can contribute towards changing the social attitudes illustrated in this story?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

- Treat my sisters and girl classmates as equals and speak up when someone makes fun of a person's looks or disability (like Bholi's stammer and pock-marks).
- Encourage parents in my neighbourhood to send girls to school.
- Refuse and oppose dowry; talk about the laws against it.
- Help weaker or shy students with studies, as Bholi's teacher did.
- Take part in awareness rallies, street plays and poster campaigns.

2 **Should girls be aware of their rights, and assert them? Should girls and boys have the same rights, duties and privileges? What are some of the ways in which society treats them differently? When we speak of 'human rights', do we differentiate between girls' rights and boys' rights?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

- **Yes,** girls should know their rights (education, equality, safety, choice in marriage) and assert them, as Bholi did.
- Girls and boys should have the **same rights, duties and privileges**; our Constitution gives equality to all.
- **Differences in society:** boys get better education (Ramlal's sons went to college); girls are married early, burdened with housework, denied freedom, judged by looks, and dowry is demanded; female foeticide.
- **Human rights** belong to every human being, so there is **no difference** between girls' rights and boys' rights.

3 **Do you think the characters in the story were speaking to each other in English? If not, in which language were they speaking? (You can get clues from the names of the persons and the non-English words used in the story.)**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

No. They were most likely speaking **Hindi** (or a local dialect of North India). Clues: names like Ramlal, Sulekha, Bishamber, Lakshmi; words like **Pitaji, izzat, Numberdar, Tehsildar sahib**; and customs like the turban as a sign of honour and garlanding at the sacred fire.

🎉 **Chapter 8 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**